

Classroom Discussion Techniques

Setting the Student Up for Success During Classroom Discussions

Listed below are some techniques to set student's up for successful participation in classroom discussion.

Idea	Description	Ideas
Prepare Students to Participate	Sometimes it can be difficult for students to come up with an answer quickly during a classroom discussion. Help these students by allowing them to prepare for participation in advance.	Send the student a list of discussion questions or prompts one day in advance of class. Send the student one question one day in advance of class. Tell them to prepare to answer that question during the coming class session. During classroom discussion, ask the class a question. Provide the students with a few minutes to jot down a few notes. After students have had a few minutes to gather their thoughts, ask them to share their answers with the class.
Get Students Talking	Sometime students don't like saying anything during class, let alone something meaningful about the course content. Help these students by warming them up and getting them talking about small stuff as soon as they walk in the classroom.	At the beginning of class, write an icebreaker question on the board and have students answer the question at the beginning of class. During classroom discussion, have students answer questions with a partner or in a small group first. Then, have students share their responses with the whole class.

Provide Visual Supports	Sometimes it can be difficult for students to quickly process a question presented orally. Help these students by providing the question in written format too.	Instead of just saying a question out loud during classroom discussion, provide the student with visual support by writing the question on the board or typing it into a slide in your power point presentation.
Provide an Example Response	Sometimes students understand the question being asked, but don't know how to respond. Help these students by providing an example response before requiring them to respond.	After you ask a question during classroom discussion, have a student respond to the question, giving the struggling student an example of how to respond. This only works when there is more than one right answer to a question.
Direct Questions to Specific Students	If you know that there is a specific question well-suited for a specific student, don't open the question up to the whole class. Help these students by directing that questions toward them.	During the classroom discussion, call on the specific student and then pose the question.

Supporting Students' Contributions During Classroom Discussions

Listed below are some techniques to use when a student is struggling to meaningfully participate in classroom discussion.

Idea	Description	Example
Draw Connections	Sometimes students provide great examples, but don't connect their examples to content. In these situations, affirm the student's contribution and draw a connection between the student's contribution and the content being discussed.	For Example: "Sarah, that is an excellent thought! What you shared is a perfect example of (insert relevant topic / content)."
Paraphrase / Interpret	Sometimes students provide great examples, but forget important details. In these situations, paraphrase the student's contribution and add in the missing details.	For Example: "Sarah, that is an excellent thought! You are right, (insert student's point). It's also important to remember that (insert missing detail)."
Rephrase Your Question	Sometimes a student's contribution makes it clear that they misunderstood the question being asked. In these situations, thank the student for their contribution and rephrase the question.	For Example: "Sarah, thanks for your contribution. It seems like my question wasn't very clear. Let me try asking it a different way...."
Ask a Question about the Student's Comment	Sometimes it isn't clear why a student shared a particular point. In these situations, ask the student a follow-up question to gain clarity and understanding.	For Example: "Sarah, I didn't understand the point you were making. Can you tell me a little bit more about (insert the point of confusion) to help me understand?"

Hold On To It	Sometimes students make great contributions, but at the wrong time. When a student makes a valuable contribution at the wrong time, tell the student to “hold on to it.” When the time is right, request that the student re-share their contribution.	For Example: “Sarah, that is an excellent thought! Let’s finish this conversation and come back to your point in just a minute.”
Share Your Confusion	Sometimes what a student shares during a discussion and why they share it is unclear. In these situations, it is okay to share your confusion. When doing so, recognize the student’s willingness to participate, share your confusion, and make a plan to talk with them about it more.	For Example: “Sarah, thank you so much for participating. I am a little confused about (insert point of confusion). I would love to talk with you about this idea more after class is over to make sure we are on the same page.”
Set Participation Goals	Some students struggle with the lack of defined expectations for participation in classroom discussions. For these students, support their participation by providing them with personal goals.	For students who don’t enjoy participating in discussions: Talk with them and agree upon a realistic goal / the minimum number of times they need to participate during each class session. For students who enjoy participating in classroom discussions too much: Talk with them and determine the total number of times they should participate during each class session.
Correct a Misunderstanding	There are times when students don’t fully understand the course content. Their misunderstandings can lead them to share incorrect information during discussions. In these situations, it is important to respectfully correct the student’s misunderstanding.	For Example: “Sarah, I really appreciate your willingness to share with the class. Part of what you shared is correct, but I want to make sure that everything is clear...”